anticipate her own punishment and banish herself. In faraway Mecca – according to Nizamuddin, who tells a similar story – Maham might pray for Akbar, even if she could not see him or serve him in any other way.

Akbar's love for his mother and mother figures is one of his defining traits. He was closer to Hamida and his anakas, Jiji and Maham especially, than to any other woman in his life, reliant upon them for both affection and advice. The thought of Bairam attacking Maham, of forcing her to leave, was unbearable.

'The Emperor,' writes Badauni, 'could not make up his mind to part with [Maham Anaka].' They sailed back to Delhi; Shihabuddin came out and had 'the bliss' of escorting them to the city.[90]

Instead of a frank conversation with his protégé, therefore, Bairam received an arch message from him: 'Since without your leave and approval I have journeyed thus far, all my attendants are in the uttermost terror . . .' It would be well if Bairam showed himself 'amicably inclined' towards them.[91] Soon enough, Bairam would get even more puzzling news: Akbar had issued an edict declaring that Bairam was 'banished from our sight'.[92]

The regent had been sacked.

Too late, Bairam felt the reins slipping from his hands. He sent urgent messages to Delhi protesting his good faith, but Shihabuddin had already fortified the city and, with Maham, was sending news of Bairam's fall far and wide. The plot, as one historian puts it memorably, 'was carried out at the point of the tongue'.[93] Talk of such reversals travels fast: 'One by one, and two by two,' writes Abul Fazl, the chiefs abandoned the regent and converged upon Delhi, to be greeted by Shihabuddin and Maham, who had taken over Bairam's office together and were promising lavish rewards to all comers.[94]

Too late, Bairam held a council. Some among his remaining loyalists – these included Shaikh Gada'i of the singing parties and Wali Beg, the man who gave Akbar his first cheetah, both Shias – suggested war. Too late, Bairam decided to go and speak to Akbar instead.

Having spent such energy in keeping them apart, Maham would hardly allow a meeting now, with victory in her grasp. If Bairam came to Delhi, said Akbar's advisers, the court should 'go to Lahore before he arrived'. If Bairam followed, Akbar 'should go to Kabul'.[95] The very thought of